religion, like the rights of Kashmiri Pandits brutalised by Islamist terrorists and driven from their homes in the Kashmir Valley to become refugees in their own land, and some which directly challenged other religions, such as the advocacy of a Uniform Civil Code to replace the personal laws of religious minorities.

The 'Muslim threat' presented itself in multiple ways—Muslim illegal migrants in Assam, reactionary Muslim conservatives opposing a liberal Supreme Court judgment in the Shah Bano Case (in which the court's award of alimony to a Muslim widow was then overturned by the government passing a law obliging her to seek support from the Waqf Board), and angry Muslim politicians denouncing Salman Rushdie's 'blasphemy' in his novel, *The Satanic Verses*. To those repelled by such developments, the BJP offered not just negative condemnation but a positive alternative cause dear to many Hindu hearts—a campaign to resurrect a legendary ancient temple to the birthplace of Lord Rama (the Ram Janmabhoomi) which had reputedly stood on the site of a disused sixteenth-century mosque, the Babri Masjid, in the north Indian holy town of Ayodhya.

The evidence for this claim is contested, though there is little doubt that some temple had indeed stood there, since in 1975, well before the mosque's destruction, the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) unearthed fourteen pillar bases of kasauti stone with Hindu motifs in the foundations. Yet, very few details are available about the temple or whether it had indeed been destroyed to construct the masjid. But there is no doubt it is deeply entrenched in popular Hindu belief that this precisely was where Rama was born and where he must be worshipped. If this can be achieved without inflicting pain on Indian Muslims, and while finding some way to make up for the barbarous destruction of the Babri Masjid, the nation will heave a sigh of relief, but a quarter-century after the demolition of the masjid, the case pends in the Supreme Court, and the temple remains unbuilt, its absence a potent symbol for the Hindutva movement and a perennial vote-winner for its acolytes.

The Ram Janmabhoomi campaign was incendiary politics, given the inflammatory potency of calls to replace a mosque with a temple; but for the BJP, it worked. The party's leader, L. K. Advani, rode across the